in January 2018; this declaration was signed by more than 1,800 religious scholars from mainstream sects across the country, condemning among other acts 'suicide attacks against the state, spreading sectarianism and anarchy in the name of religion and issuing a call to jihad without the consent of the state' as un-Islamic (Dawn 2018). The state through the NCEPG and declarations like the Paigham-i-Pakistan is using a 'soft' approach to combating terrorism in Pakistan. While Paigham-i-Pakistan has brought religious scholars together, where the message will be promoted through academic and religious institutions, mosques and state institutions, there is also a recognition that other social institutions, such as news and media outlets including social media, need to play their part in assisting the state in its fight against terrorism. However, as the arguments in this book will illustrate, this 'soft' approach is increasingly targeting peaceful citizens who may be challenging the writ of the security state.

While suicide bombers and terrorists were already being targeted by security forces, the nature of the terrorist threat has also evolved, with university-educated individuals being found guilty of engaging in terrorist activities. In September 2017 Minister of Interior Ahsan Iqbal outlined concerns about the evolving nature of the threat, emphasizing the need 'to formulate a national narrative to counter the extremists' agenda', where 'the youth must be imparted with the importance of peace enjoined by Islamic injunctions and the vision of Pakistan'. The danger of the Pakistani-educated youth following the path towards extremism and terrorism was also highlighted in May 2017 by the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) that organized a seminar in the army auditorium entitled 'Role of Youth in Rejecting Extremism'. The keynote address was delivered by the chief of army staff (COAS) Pakistan highlighting the problem of extremism and the importance of the country's youth in challenging this problem. As the COAS observed, 'We are standing at a crossroads; ten years down the line, we will either be enjoying the fruits of a youth dividend or suffering at the hands of a youth bulge, especially with the youth which remains vulnerable to extremism' (Express Tribune 2017b). The various speakers at the seminar, including the chairman of the Higher Education Commission, highlighted the importance of educational institutions in creating an atmosphere of critical learning that would challenge the potential of extremism among the youth (Pakistan Army 2017). The emergence of university-educated individuals such as Omar Sheikh, Saad Aziz, Hafiz Nasir, Azfar Ishrat, Hammad Adil, Tanveer Gondal, Hassan bin Nazeer, Abdul Karim Sarosh Siddiqui and Noreen Jabbar Laghari among others who have turned to terrorism has added another dimension to the discourse on terrorism in Pakistan. The traditional threat from groups in Federally